

THE DELUXE LIFE



DELHI

■ By Sandeep Unnithan

"My hands smell like a rose," whispers a stocky gentleman in linen trousers and pointed black elf shoes after five minutes of squirting and sniffing a tray-load of fragrances on his raised wrist. The attendant at the counter giggles politely. Light strains of jazz waft through 170 sq marbled metres of Peter

the corseted tyranny of the last century.

Done up in the trademark Chanel black and white, the swish store is a bubble far removed from the chaos of the traffic outside. It is further away from the Indian reality, which discovered post-liberalisation that Chanel was not the only thing separating France from the UK and that the trademark—interlocking Cs—wasn't copied from cheap Chinese bags. So you have rows of white ceramic

ager Martine Beaumont, flashing her blue eyes. The winter collection, a row of black-and-white sporty outfits, is on display and Chanel spokesperson Marielou Phillips picks a light black jacket and swirls to demonstrate the fit. "See, it always fits right," she exults.

There are no price tags. At the dizzying heights of high fashion there usually aren't any. If the price-sensitive other India were in here, they would wonder what on earth would make people spend the equiva-

The bling thing

RAVI S SAHANI

Invisible price tags, luxe bags and the trademark Cs. Paris's hushed couture elegance embraces the newly-acquired affluence of an aggressively urban India.



Marino-designed minimalist elegance. Embedded in Delhi's Imperial hotel, India's sole Chanel store opened two years ago. The muted Art Deco premises were selected because they were a fitting show window for the Parisian bling factory founded by the iconic Gabrielle 'Coco' Chanel, who redefined fashion in the 1920s—raising hemlines and liberating women from

diamond encrusted watches with rap star written all over them, giant bug eyeshades—the kind recommended by designer *du jour* Rachel Zoe—leather handbags with the distinctive quilted pattern, and of course, bottles of Chanel

No 5 that fly off the shelves, along with an exclusive line of perfumes sold only in its stores. "I like changing the displays often, it's good energy," says store man-

TRUE ESSENCE: A glimpse of India's only Chanel store lent of the cost of a Maruti 800, with air-conditioning, on a diamond encrusted wristwatch. As they say, if you have to ask, you can't afford it. Those who don't ask, usually drive up the cobble-stoned hotel driveway behind a three-pointed star. The other usual suspects are hotel guests or the odd film star like Hema Malini trying out designer hand bags. So now we know what erstwhile dream girls dream about.

Rs 87,000
IS THE STARTING
PRICE FOR
A CLASSIC
CHANEL HAND
BAG